

BULBS

Embracing a wide range of decorative plants, bulbs provide exciting effects throughout the year, with large drifts of snowdrops in late winter, daffodils and tulips in spring, the exquisite perfume of lilies and vibrant dahlia colors in summer, and the spidery flowers of nerines in fall.

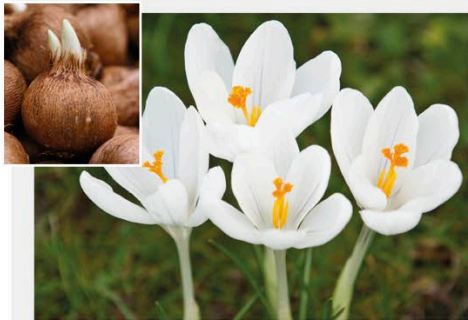
BULB DEFINITIONS

Bulbs are divided into smaller plant categories, including true bulbs, corms, and tubers. All of these swollen, underground, food-storage organs help the bulb to survive periods of drought.



Bulb

A true bulb is a storage organ made up of stems and fleshy leaves inside. Examples include daffodils, tulips, and eucomis (above).



Corm

Swollen stems that have adapted to store food are known as corms. They appear solid throughout, and include crocuses (above).



Tuber

Tuberous plants have swollen underground roots or stems. Examples include cyclamen, dahlias, (above), and begonias.

What are bulbs?

The term bulb can be used to describe all swollen, underground, food-storage organs, and includes true bulbs as well as corms, rhizomes, and tubers. True bulbs have fleshy scales—modified leaves or leaf bases—that overlap and are often enclosed in a papery tunic, as in narcissi, or they may be naked and loosely arranged like lily bulbs.

Corms are compressed and enlarged stem bases, usually enclosed in a fibrous or papery tunic, as in the crocus. Each corm lasts 1 year, and is replaced by a new one after flowering. Tubers, such as cyclamen, are solid, underground sections of modified stems or roots and seldom possess scales or tunics. Rhizomes are modified stems that creep at or just below soil level, and may be thin and wiry or swollen and fleshy.

A few bulbs are evergreen, but most grow and bloom during a short season, then die back to below ground level. Their leaves produce the food store for

BELOW Carpets of spring color

A selection of daffodils has been naturalized in the grass beneath silver birches and spring-flowering trees, creating a sea of nodding yellow flowers.



SIZE CATEGORIES USED WITHIN THIS GROUP

Large	Medium	Small
over 30in (75cm)	9–30in (23–75cm)	up to 9in (23cm)

the following year, which is why the foliage must not be cut down after flowering, but allowed to wither naturally.

When below ground, bulbs are described as dormant but they are, in fact, ripening and developing the following year's flowers, and must be planted in a suitable site to thrive. Bulbs that originate from dry, hot climates, such as nerines and watsonias, need warm, dry conditions when dormant to aid ripening and flower formation, while those from woodland or other damp, shaded habitats, such as bluebells (*Hyacinthoides*) and snowdrops (*Galanthus*) require a cool, slightly moist spot.

Designing with bulbs

There are bulbs to suit all garden designs and planting styles. They range in size from the tiny *Iris danfordiae* and fall daffodil (*Sternbergia lutea*), both suitable for a scree or rock garden, to carpeting erythroniums for the dappled shade of a woodland garden, midrange alliums and tulips for a hot, sunny border, and tall, slender, regal lilies that produce highly scented flowers on stems up to 6ft (1.8m) in height. The